

Week 10 - Church as a living community

Welcome to the 9th and final week of New Beginnings!

Last week we talked about living out the mission. And we will continue today with the theme **The Church, a living community.**

In this final week of the New Beginning course, we will talk about what Jesus came to build, the object of His love: the Church.

The first point we will address together is:

1. The mission of the Church

I believe that God never intended for the Church to be merely a gathering place where people could come, but I am convinced that the Church is called to be a living and functional community with the common goal of serving God together.

The Church should be like a magnet that attracts people and gives them a sense of belonging and purpose.

The Church is the expression of Jesus, the hope of the world. It is the means that God uses to bring the lost back to Him.

Matthew 16:17-18 (S21) - Jesus replied, "Blessed are you, Simon son of Jonah, for this was not revealed to you by flesh and blood, but by my Father in heaven." And I tell you that you are Peter, and on this rock, I will build my Church, and the gates of Hades will not prevail against it.

Paul also speaks of the church as a group of called people who know their calling! When you know that you are the church, then you realize that together, we are the church. Then the way we believe and how each person behaves makes the difference!

2. We are called by God and called into this world.

The Greek word for the early Church is "Ekklesia," composed of "kaleo" (called) and "ek" (out of/outside). "The Church" therefore means "called out of."

Called out of the world, separated from the rest of the world.

Jesus mentioned several times to His disciples that He chose them from the world, but that He called them out of the world. He tells us that we are no longer of this world:

John 17:16 (S21) - They are not of the world, just as I am not of the world.

John 15:19 (S21) - If you were of the world, the world would love you as its own. You are not of the world, but I have chosen you out of the world; therefore the world hates you.

We are called, but for what purpose?

Why is the people of God referred to as a "called body"?

Before discovering the incredible call of God for His children, let me clarify one thing:

"Called out of the world" does not mean that we are not in this world, it simply means that we are not of this world.

"Called out of the world" does not mean that we are not responsible for its well-being; you are even more responsible!

So, what is this call?

A. We have received a divine call, a call that comes from God.

It is God Himself who extends a holy call to us.

1 Peter 5:10 "The God of all grace, who has called you to His eternal glory in Christ Jesus, after you have suffered a little while, will Himself perfect, confirm, strengthen, and establish you."

B. We have been called to enter into communion with God

=> He called us to stay with Him! An invitation to be with Him.

=> We have been called to enter into communion with God.

1 Corinthians 1:9 (S21) "God is faithful, who has called you into fellowship with his Son, Jesus Christ our Lord."

C. We have been called from darkness into His light

In Him, there is a radiant future that we can discover as we walk with Him in our daily lives.

We have been called to a better life and not a worse one!

We have been called from darkness into His light.

1 Peter 2:9 (S21) "But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people belonging to God, that you may declare the praises of him who called you out of darkness into his wonderful light."

The call of God is a call to turn away from sin and wickedness to walk on the path of righteousness. When the apostle Paul was sent to proclaim the Gospel, he was sent to

"open their eyes so that they may turn from darkness to light and from the power of Satan to God..." - Acts of the Apostles 26:18 (S21).

D. We have been called to a new kingdom

In Christ, we have been called to inherit the Kingdom of Heaven. The Bible declares that we are co-heirs of the kingdom of God in Jesus Christ.

It's a powerful call!

We have been called into the Kingdom of God.

1 Thessalonians 2:12 (S21) "we encouraged, comforted, and urged you to walk in a manner worthy of God, who calls you into His kingdom and glory."

Those who have heard the call of the Lord and responded to it are fellow citizens with the saints. They are no longer under the authority and dominion of Satan; they have become citizens of the eternal kingdom, placed under the authority of Jesus Christ. As citizens of the Kingdom, they enjoy all the joys and privileges.

We find eternal hope in this heavenly perspective, as the apostle Peter says in 1 Peter 3:9: "You know that it was to this that you were called, so that you might inherit a blessing.

Or the Apostle Paul when he writes:

Ephesians 1:18 (S21) "I pray that he may enlighten the eyes of your heart so that you may know what is the hope to which he has called you, what are the riches of his glorious inheritance among the saints."

Those who have been called by God have this sure and solid hope of living eternally in the presence and communion of God in heaven.

3. What does the Church look like?

Since the Church has been called by God to remain in communion with Him, called to walk in His light and in the Kingdom of Heaven, we are called to become more and more like Jesus to reflect His heart and His Kingdom as we grow in our communion with Him.

What does the Kingdom of God look like? Once we discover it, we know what we - the church - can become.

Here is the Church that we believe it is destined to be and to experience.

⇒ **An attractive church**

Relevant, joyful, beautiful, and full of life

Ephesians 5:25-27 (S21) - Husbands, love your wives as Christ loved the Church. He gave himself for her to lead her to holiness after purifying and washing her with the water of the word, to present to himself this glorious Church, without spot, wrinkle, or anything like that, but holy and blameless.

Acts 2:46-47 (S21) - Every day, with perseverance, they met together in the temple courts; they broke bread in their homes and ate together with glad and sincere hearts. They praised God and had the favor of all the people. The Lord added to the Church daily those who were being saved.

⇒ A relational church

We are called to unity through our friendships, we are called to experience community, to be interconnected, open to others, and to enjoy life together.

From the perspective of the kingdom of heaven, unity is not a kind of cloning to make us all resemble each other.

Unity according to the heart of God is found in diversity. And true unity does not merely tolerate diversity, it celebrates diversity!

Acts 1:14 (S21) - All these with one accord devoted themselves to prayer, together with the women, Mary the mother of Jesus, and his brothers.

⇒ A church on a mission

Jesus entrusted us with a mission on earth that we can read in Matthew 28:19: Go, make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit.

A church on a mission is a victorious church, equipped with the purpose of:

a. Reach and rescue people, wherever they are

We can do this by inviting people and connecting them with the church so that they can come into contact with God through it.

b. Show people that there is a better way to live - God's way!

Matthew 5:14 (S21) - You are the light of the world.

Called and equipped to live differently and walk with God.

Matthew 5:3-13: The Beatitudes

Luke 6:32 If you love those who love you, what credit is that to you? Sinners also love those who love them.

We are called to welcome people into the family of God. God is the perfect Father, and His heart is best represented when His children are united and work together in unity.

c. Being active in restoring a lost world

Being counter-culture, being an agent of change.

An influence for the better.

Romans 12:2 Do not conform to the present age, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may discern what is the will of God, what is good, acceptable, and perfect.

Helping people, bringing hope and restoration where it is needed.

God calls us not to be afraid of what is happening in the world, but to be bold, to thrive, to not fear the unknown, knowing that God is on our side, and that He lives in us.

Being active means doing everything we can to be innovative, and finding new ways to connect with this world and show people how much God loves them.

If you haven't already done so, I encourage you to get involved actively: find a Connect group where you can build friendships that make a difference, start serving on a team, and see your life transformed as we all commit to fulfilling the wonderful mission God has for us, for His Church.

THE BIG IDEA

The Church is primarily a community of believers who are equipped and called together to represent Christ on earth and reach this world with the good news of the Gospel.

We don't just go to church, we are the Church!

DISCUSSION

How do you see the church now?

What do you think you can do to help the church resemble the previously depicted image: an attractive, relational, and mission-focused church?

TARGET PRAYER SUBJECT

Jesus taught us how to pray for God's will to be done on earth as it is in heaven. Let's follow this example so that we may be those who want to manifest the presence of God and the life

of the Kingdom. Let us pray that God strengthens us, purifies us, and fills us so that we can be the light in this world.

NEXT STEP

Do you serve in or outside the church?

Talk to your leader about how you could get involved in order to grow and make a difference in your local community.